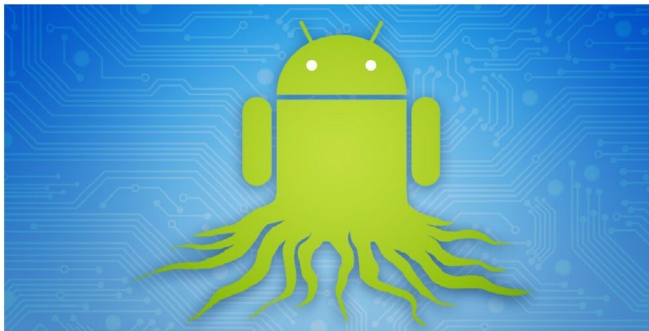


Should You Root Your Android Device?

There are many settings that can be tweaked in an Android device; however, these tweaks are restricted to what the manufacturer permits. Rooting an Android device or gaining root access allows tweaking the device at a very deep level. This article covers the pros and cons of rooting an Android device while instructing readers how to do it.



Having the freedom to tweak your operating system has been and will always be of great importance for any open source enthusiast. With Google backing the porting of Linux-based operating systems to handheld and portable devices, this freedom has increased manifold. Companies manufacturing mobile phones and handheld devices have had to give in to Android's growing popularity as it's competing head-to-head for space with other popular mobile operating systems such as the iOS, Blackberry OS and other proprietary operating systems. A number of tweaks and functionalities have been added to the most recent version, Android KitKat, which was released at the end of October 2013. However, a number of users continue to be on earlier Android versions such as Jelly Bean (on devices with low hardware configurations).

As with other open source desktop operating systems, it is possible for Android users to tweak or change any part of the system within the limitations set by the open source community and by the licences. Although there are several apps available on the famous Google Play store, Android primarily doesn't allow its users to make any changes to the system. This can, however, be achieved by using a method commonly referred to as the rooting of an Android device. A device that has undergone this procedure is referred to as a rooted phone or tablet. The

name is derived from the term 'root access', which is actually the ability to attain permissions only restricted to super-users or administrators. Rooting allows you to perform a number of operations that would have been otherwise impossible because of the limitations set by the carriers or phone manufacturers.

Although rooting your device might sound like a great idea, there are several disadvantages that negate its advantages. Before I go ahead with the procedure for rooting an Android device, let us look at the factors that will affect your decision on rooting.

What you might lose

Bricking your phone

When you're tampering with your phone's operating system, you should be aware that one wrong move could damage the device's software, turning the phone into a useless brick. So if you are wary of taking risks, please refrain from trying this procedure. Although the risk is minimal, rooting your device is still quite a risky business. So, you need to be absolutely sure of what you do.

Manufacturer's warranty

The process of rooting in almost all cases challenges several clauses in the agreement with the hardware manufacturer and results in the warranty becoming invalid.